Consolidation of Maratha Power

Shivaji resumed his raids after his father's death and conquered Javali (1656) from the Maratha chief Chandrarao More. He also reduced all the lesser Maratha chiefs around Pune to subordination. The soldiers of Bijapur from the hill fortresses acquired by Sultan of Bijapur were driven out and replaced with his own commanders. These moves and the defeat of Bijapur army sent to punish Shivaji alarmed the Mughal officials. When the Mughals made a punitive expedition, Shivaji boldly confronted them. In 1659 he killed Afzal Khan, a notable general of Bijapur. In 1663 he wounded and chased away the Mughal general and Aurangzeb's uncle Shaista Khan. To cap these bold acts, he audaciously directed his soldiers to plunder Surat (1664), the major Mughal port on the Arabian Sea.

Shivaji and Aurangzeb

After Shivaji plundered Surat, Aurangzeb swung into action. An army under the command of a Rajput general, Raja Jai Singh, was ordered to destroy Shivaji and annex Bijapur. Shivaji finally sought peace, yielded the fortresses he had seized and accepted service as a mansabhdar in the Mughal service for the conquest of Bijapur. He also agreed to visit the imperial court at Agra, on the advice of Jai Singh only to suffer humiliation, which led him to escape, by hiding in a basket.

Aurangzeb was determined to stop the Maratha interference in his expeditions against the Deccan kingdoms. He attempted to patch up with Shivaji, but those efforts failed. In 1670, the Mughal army was helpless when Shivaji again plundered Surat. In 1674, Shivaji crowned himself by assuming the title of Chhtrapati and the coronation of Shivaji was celebrated with great splendour at Raigarh, as the occasion was the founding of a new kingdom and a new dynasty. Shivaji's aged mother Jijabai, who had lived to see her son crowned the king, passed away a few days after the coronation, with her life wish fulfilled. Shivaji spent his last years trying to bring his son Shambhuji into his ways as he had defected to the Mughals. He fell ill with fever and dysentery and died in 1680.

Chhatra (parasol) pati (master or lord),is the Sanskrit equivalent of king or emperor, and was used by the Marathas, especially Shivaji.

Maratha Administration under Shivaji

Shivaji's political system consisted of three circles. At the centre was the swaraj. Shivaji was caring and would not allow the people to be harassed in any way. In the second circle, Shivaji claimed suzerainty, but he did not administer them himself. He protected the people from loot and plunder for which they were required to pay Chauth (one-fourth of the revenue as protection money) and Sardeshmukhi (an extra one-tenth, as the chieftain's due). In the third circle, Shivaji's only objective was plunder.

E4F2J1

Deshmukhs held sway over rural regions and their control was over between twenty and hundred villages. Each village had a powerful headman (Patil), who was assisted by a village accountant of a keeper of records (Kulkarni). In the absence of a strong central government, these local community level officials functioned as the true government.

7th Social Science_Term I English Unit 03.indd 125 20-07-2019 1.52.42 PM